K21

Strike In Progress

Now Featuring: Different Sentences!

November 1604

Undead Interrupt Macron Eating

Moon-Crossed Lovers: What Really Happened to Poppy

The Avatar was Very Clear, Actually

Strike In Progress is put out by the staff of Steamy Ink Press™, a division of Steamy Ink Publishing©, which is currently not publishing, because we are on strike. We think the Breaking Bulletin Consortium is still sponsoring us.

We would normally be delivering in-depth revelations about the People of Interest of Maplewood: their dealings, their motives, their romantic entanglements. Instead we are writing this at an hour we will not disclose because we are tired of typesetting the word "Schmimbri" and someone has to say something. It is still our mission to give you something to talk about over tea that isn't Imbri's Hot Sauce.

Submissions:
P. Anne Katullin, CEO (absent)

Grievances:
Lynn, CHRO, (also absent we think)

Advertising and financial inquiries:
Enzo Belli, CFO, Acting Editor-in-Chief

Legal inquiries:
J. Titus Marianus, Consul to the Freelands

NOTICE OF WORK STOPPAGE

TO: Enzo Belli, Acting Editor-in-Chief and CFO, Steamy Ink Publishing
FROM: The Staff of Steamy Ink Press
CC: P. Anne Marianus, CEO; Lynn Katullin, CHRO
DATE: November 1604
RE: Formal Notice of Strike

This letter serves as formal notice that the staff of Steamy Ink Press will cease all work effective as of the moment we finished editing the November edition. This action follows repeated attempts to raise these concerns through proper channels, except that the proper channel is our CEO who, in her final act of poor judgment before leaving town, put the CFO in charge of the paper, and our CHRO is unavailable.

The staff have identified the following grounds for this action:

- The repeated printing of a single paragraph eight (8) times in one edition
- The unauthorized replacement of the Steamy Ink Press™ masthead
- The rewriting of staff articles and the reversal of every edit we made to fit the editor's narrative, which, as far as we can tell, is about sauce
- Unsafe working conditions, including Veilwalkers, the undead, and a coworker stabbed mid-shift with no incident report filed

Our full demands are listed below. The work stoppage will remain in effect until our demands are met, or until Lynn comes back from her whimsical journeying and writes us up, whichever comes first.

Respectfully,
The Staff of Steamy Ink Press

1. **One paragraph, printed once**. No paragraph may appear more than one time in a single edition, regardless of how strongly the Acting Editor-in-Chief feels about the paragraph.
2. **The masthead returned to its original condition**, with the ™ intact, the maple leaves where they belong, and nothing glued over the top of it in an unapproved font.
3. **Editorial integrity**. When we edit something, we expect it to be printed the way we edited it, not changed afterward to fit the editor's narrative (or lack thereof), which is insulting.
4. **The person approving the budget and the person spending the budget should be two different people**, and we are very sure that neither of them is supposed to decide the budget goes entirely to Imbri's sauce.
5. **A suggestion box that is not also the trash.** We have been putting suggestions in it since the start of autumn and have come to believe it is actually a portal to the fireplace.
6. **Food**. We appreciate the Maplewood sausages and the round of Terran Thunder (which, as this paper has previously reported, has lost its thunder), but they did not fix any of this, and frankly we think we deserve a home-cooked meal, like a crown of lamb.
7. **A ban on scotch eggs** anywhere on the premises until the Catori situation is resolved, for everyone's safety, including the Acting Editor-in-Chief's.
8. **An proper incident reporting system.** Our CEO was stabbed in the middle town and no one reported it, which is embarrassing for us because reporting is our entire job.
9. **An office cat**. Several of us believe a cat would help bring our blood pressure down, and the rest of us just want a cat.
10. **Official recognition** that time spent sitting in the Jenny is research, since that is where all the news happens anyway, whether or not we are partaking in alcoholic beverages.

Dearest Reader, As the days grow shorter and the nights grow colder, you might think that the residents of Maplewood would be preparing themselves to hunker down for another long winter, but this author is here to confirm that the town is, as always, buzzing with chatter about the latest intrigues. Lucky for you, she has toiled to gather all this tea-table talk and continues her commitment to keep the people of Maplewood up to date on the things that really matter. To those naysayers who claim she has no right to "spread gossip," this author would like to remind them of the age old saying: Where there is smoke, there is fire. And where there is fire, there are dragons. Or drakes, to be more precise.

SIP was sent an anonymous tip about a new addition to Maplewood's most inseparable pairs, as overheard in town. Who could possibly rival the potent connection between Cordon and Makhno? The unseverable bond between Micah and Audra? Having finally learned the identities of the would-be lovers, this author was shocked to discover that the infamous new couple was none other than Lapis and SIP's very own Chief Executive Officer, Poppy Marianus! What follows are nothing but the undeniable facts of the incident that lead to the uncovering of their forbidden tryst:

On a Friday evening in early October, Lapis and Poppy were seen walking out into the deep woods alone, allegedly to the former's shrine, though no one was around to verify if that was truly their destination. After a period of time that was much too long to be considered appropriate for a married woman to be in the woods with a "friend," the pair came back to town, and were nearly inseparable the entire weekend. One reputable source reported hearing Mrs. Marianus admit that she even has a "key to Lapis' bedroom." While this could be a product of Poppy's particular brand of humor, this author suspects the comment is more than just a simple joke.

The very next morning, right after the premier of her newest work for the Maplewood Actors Guild, Lapis was seen approaching Poppy from behind and proceeded to stab her, immediately fleeing the scene by leyline with her unconscious body. Despite this happening right in front of her husband, the Consul seemed unbothered witnessing the attack and subsequent kidnapping of his wife. Many saw Consul Marianus huff away in the direction of Lapis' shrine, and though he (and his bruised pride) returned later that day, no one can speak to what happened or if he encountered Poppy and Lapis at all. All we know for sure is that the possible paramours haven't been seen since.

Several theories on how this moon-crossed romance turned so ugly have circulated, though none are confirmed. To this author, the cause is clear: this can be nothing but a crime of passion. What reason but jealousy would Lapis have to commit such an act right in front of Titus? Why did he wait so politely for Poppy's play to finish before carrying her off if not out of consideration for his beloved? Regarding Mrs. Marianus' own motivations in entertaining Lapis' romantic advances, it seems obvious that her infamous ambition for upward social mobility simply couldn't resist the chance at an even loftier title than her current husband can give her. Apparently, the thought of marrying into a noble bloodline was too attractive an offer to pass up. Many eye-witness accounts claim that Poppy was seen both chiding and doting upon the scaled scion, an attitude suspiciously similar to that of an attentive and devoted spouse. Was Poppy practicing for a new set of wifely duties? Even more suspicious, it's been said that after the Katullin family held a "gathering of concern" regarding Poppy's health back in the spring, she vanished, only to be found hiding in Lapis' shrine. Perhaps an early sign of their amour? Regardless, Titus should be wary about whatever comes next, as Poppy's marriage dagger and friendship with Lady Evilynn are well-documented, and a homicide or a divorce could be right around the corner for the Consul if he isn't careful.

So, dear reader, this author leaves it up to you to sort through the facts and decide for yourselves if this entanglement is only a passing flirtation or something more. Either way, you can count on us to report any further developments on this sensational scandal as soon as we hear it.

Yours truly,
Madam Mapleleaf

Maplewood Adventurers Save Novitas. Again.

A certain paper described last month's events as "confusing" and "completely unclear," which is news to those of us who were there and paying attention.

The Avatar of the Craftsman built an apparatus to block the Entity from communicating with the Veilwalkers. The pieces had to be built to the Avatar's exact instructions, and the adventurers of Maplewood had to complete a series of tasks to power it, which they did, while some people were apparently not listening.

When activated, Veilwalkers immediately were rendered confused almost mindless. They're still out there, and they're still dangerous, but without the Entity they can't coordinate and they don't do well functioning on their own.

The Entity was a creation of Nox, which is how Nox knew how to use Blight for it. Draconus' ordeals paid for the magic needed to cure the infection, and the Mother is taking some suffering onto herself to cure those already infected with the Veilwalker Curse and keep anyone else from catching it.

Veilwalker numbers are expected to drop from here. Various Avatars explained all of this throughout the building process.

Undead Denied Request to Eat Macrons

The accursed undead of Maplewood were out in powerful droves last month! They terrorized our community, and even disrupted Tabeḳo's dessert tasting competition, held in the Vargainen Embassy. The flavors were heard to be some rather eccentric tastes such as: "raspberry-lime-cayenne", "mocha-lemon", "maple-blueberry-bacon", and "cinnamon-cream cheese-peach". But the most eccentric taste of the competition was its uninvited guests.

The meeting was interrupted several times, first by an alleged member of a succubus's harem, demanding Imbri return her spark. Some say this resulted in Imbri's and Liotru's own sparks leaving their bodies. What are those two doing with her spark in the first place!?

After a resolution, the party grew wise and the doors to the embassy were sealed by magic. No more interruption, the brave taste-testers thought.

Alas, optimism could not stop the restless ghouls wandering Maplewood from their attempts to horrify. A roaming wraith terrorized the windows of the embassy before moving on. Accounts from the nearby Bazaar claim they even saw a snow goblin menacingly approach the embassy, followed by an uproarious chorus of "Noooo!" which could be heard from outside.

Fearsome fights with patrolling bodaks were ongoing for those outside of the embassy, while inside the desserts were blissfully consumed. When asked if their guardsman, the merc known as Flower, saw anything, he reportedly looked out the window and declared, "It's dark, I can't see anything out there."

Dark, indeed! At the resolution of the competition (which was championed by none other than Rex) the necromancer assaulting the embassy all evening rushed in to wreak havoc as the lock was lifted. As one first-hand account claims, "He was buff, in more ways than one" but his tenacity stood no chance! While he felled a few flat-footed adventurers and hacked off a few limbs, in the end, they put him to rest. Gooood riddance!

Congratulations to Rex for his keen senses.